encounter, you still need to be aware of the overhang limitations and leverage effects. Stay within the bounds recommended by the manufacturer and even temper those recommendations to the safer side if you think appropriate. By far and away the most critical issues are bar support on the front end and the locking mechanism for the bar in the rear support of that design. Be certain you are cognizant of supporting the front of the bar in all instances being certain you don't ever let it slip off the front rest on either side. If your design includes using a bar capture system on the rear, use the safety pin, locking mechanism or whatever you are provided with by the manufacturer to ensure that the back end of the bar always stays within their trap. A mishap at either end can create unsafe conditions in the blink of an eye. Of course, all of the standard good turning safety practices still apply as well and you should be using all of the appropriate PPE whenever you are turning.

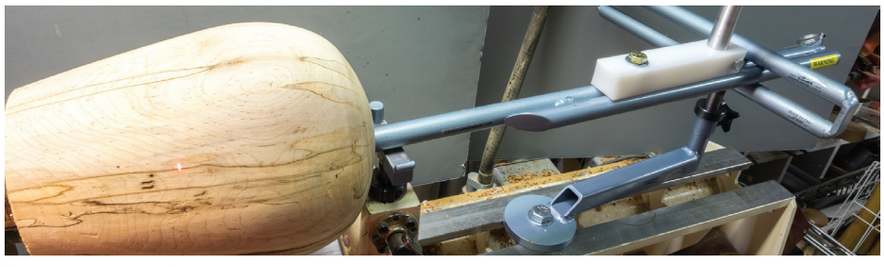
Care must be taken to ensure your bar doesn't slip off your toolrest. Custom hollowing rests provide stops

Regardless of the bar design, the safety pin to prevent coming out of the trap, depending on design, is imperative

Question yourself on your needs

As you think about selecting any of the available hollowing systems, you probably should ask yourself several basic questions. The answers to these will usually point you to the hollowing system(s) that can meet your needs best. How big will your typical hollowed turning be? Working on a mini-lathe versus an extended bed large swing lathe along with your choice of turned piece size can help point you correctly to the right sized unit. How deep or, more appropriately, how far over the rest will you need to work? Hollowing 150 or 200mm deep is far less demanding than hollowing half a metre or so down into a vessel. How thin will the walls of your work need to be? Nearly any rig will let you work to whatever wall thickness your skills will allow but bigger work with thin walls may drive the selection of a laser and possibly a centre steady. Both of these are handy to have but are additional costs that may not be essential if you do thicker walled work that isn't particularly deep. Beyond the laser for wall thickness knowledge, there are now several video options available, but these will be covered in a future article. Are you going to be working through a small opening? While most hollowing rigs can be but aren't often used for a bowl type turning, they are usually used to hollow vessels. If the opening at the top of the vessel will be small with respect to the size of the turning, your choices for a hollowing system might be impacted. Perhaps the most difficult question is, will your system need to grow? You may work on a mini now but there may be a larger lathe in your future. Many systems are adaptable to a certain degree so thinking through this a bit may prevent the purchase of another unit later on.

Your first decision is to determine your needs for depth of hollowing or reach over the toolrest



Hollowing systems offer a laser attachment that will help with determining wall thickness as you are cutting

Adjusted to your desired wall thickness, when the laser beam falls off the edge of the turning you are there

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